

BOILING Cauldron

Nine years after Jyoti Basu retired, the CPI(M) is losing its vice-like grip on the state

1977: The Left Front government formed on June 21 in West Bengal with Jyoti Basu as chief minister. All political detenus freed and the path-breaking three-tier Panchayati Raj law is passed.

2000: Basu retires after 23 years as chief minister. Buddhadeb Bhattacharya takes over.

2006: Seventh Left Front Government sworn in on May 18. Bhattacharya and Ratan Tata announce Tata Motors' small-car factory in Singur, Hooghly. In July, farmers protest acquisition of 997.11 acres of land in Singur. Mamata Banerjee marches to Singur from Kolkata with Trinamool cadres. She is prevented by CPI(M) cadres and cops from reaching Singur. Violence spreads across the state.

2007: Villagers of Sahanapara, Singur, uproot 30 pillars from the Tata factory fence and set it on fire in January. State government leases about 997 acres of land in Singur to the Tatas for 90 years.

2008: Panchayat polls in Singur in May, in which the ruling CPI(M) party loses all seats in Singur. Banerjee says she will picket outside the Tata factory if the 400 acres of land is not returned to farmers. In October, the Tatas pull out from Singur.

2009: Left Front loses to Trinamool-Congress combine in Lok Sabha elections in May. Anti-CPI(M) violence by Maoists and locals erupts in Lalgarh in June. Police and paramilitary forces are deployed to contain it.

except in West Bengal. Bhattacharya pleaded for Central help and got paramilitary forces to join his state police. But yet again, in Delhi, the man put his foot in his mouth when he declared in a televised press conference that Maoist leader Chhatradhar Mahato was a Trinamool member. Hell broke loose and Banerjee, now the railways minister, frothed at the mouth. Later in the day, a shaken Bhattacharya told the same news conference that he was giving "serious thought" to banning the Maoists. The Centre was quicker on the draw; it emphatically pre-empted him and extended the ban on the Naxalites.

With the shadow of Lalgarh looming large, there was not a single celebration of any consequence in the state as the Left Front stepped into its 33rd year of governance on June 21. The West Bengal CPI(M) is in mourning. Trinamool leader and Union Minister of State for Rural Development Shishir

Adhikari, who had been at the forefront of the Singur-Nandigram movement, says, "The police forces have been briefed by the Government to finish off the tribals in the name of the operation. The cops seemed to know the tribals by name. How would that be possible if they are not locals camouflaging as policemen?" Adhikari says it was easy to pinpoint why the CPI(M) had been rejected. "Singur was the nucleus, Nandigram the source of self-defence and now, Khejuri, from where arms are being unearthed daily from CPI(M) houses, is the final exposure," he says. He insists that the CPI(M) had failed to realise that gunpoint rule could take them only up to a certain point which, in this case, had been 32 long years.

The angst is running high. RSP Minister and CPI(M) ally Kshiti Goswami doesn't pull his punches. "The chief minister is also the police minister. He must understand that the administra-

THE TATA MOTORS PLANT IN SINGUR BEING DISMANTLED (BELOW); VILLAGERS FLEE FROM VIOLENT CPI(M) CADRES IN NANDIGRAM (RIGHT)



The Centre stepped in and banned the Maoists even as

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